For all his good works, Caldwell was a man of his time, a firm believer in the combined blessings of the Pax Britannica and Protestant Christianity. But that should not obscure the wide-ranging nature of his scholarship, not least his pioneering study of the Tamil language and its origins. Taking up from where Ellis had left off, Caldwell recognised that the four main spoken languages of the South – Tamil, Malayalam, Kannada and Telugu – formed a distinct language family of their own, which he, too, proposed to call 'Dravidian'. 'The word I have chosen is "Dravidian", from *Drāviḍa*,' wrote Caldwell in the introduction to his ground-breaking *Comparative Grammar of the Dravidian or South Indian Family of Languages*, published in 1856. 'It is a term which has already been used more or less distinctively by Sanskrit philologists, as a generic appellation for the South Indian people and their languages, and it is the only single term they ever seem to have used in this manner. I have, therefore, no doubt of the propriety of adopting it.'

This Dravidian language family, he argued, was quite distinct from Sanskrit, with which it had nothing in common other than loan words: 'My own theory is that the Dravidian languages occupy a position of their own between the languages of the Indo-European family and those of the Turanian or Scythina group – not quite a midway position, but one considerably nearer the latter than the former.'

In challenging the accepted view of the time that Sanskrit was the only significant source of India's language and culture, Caldwell helped to draw attention to the unique cultural identity of the Dravidian peoples of South India. It was the Brahmins, he argued, who had introduced what he termed 'idol-worship' to the South, together with 'the Puranic system of religion' and the Brahminical concept of caste which had reduced former rulers, warriors and farmers to the status of Shudras. Above all, it was the Brahmins who had undermined and reduced the status of Tamil literature by replacing it with Sanskrit. Paternalistic and imperialistic